



THE SPACE RACE

The increasing competition between the US and the USSR led to many rapid advancements, including the first man to orbit Earth

While the Soviets sought to unify all of their efforts into a centralised system, the Americans preferred having several different arms – the army, navy, private agencies, etc – trying their own experiments with a very light central cohesion. The result, naturally, was that the Soviets took a huge lead and managed to beat the Americans in launching the first artificial satellite, Sputnik, in 1957.

The effect of Sputnik's launch on the American public's minds was that of alarm and panic. Suddenly, it felt like they were behind the Soviets and the communist ideology was winning. The need for a centralised agency to take charge of the country's space efforts.

A turning point came in 1958 when US President Eisenhower asked his